

STARS IN Their Eyes



Residential football academies in India have a chequered past

Set up in Jamshedpur by the Tata Steel Sports Foundation in 1987, it is regarded as the premier training centre in India. Over 100 players from the academy have played for the country.

Set up in 1998, this academy's problem is its scattered facilities. Despite a capacity of 55, only six of its players have made to the national team.

The Haldia-based academy, set up in 2004, by Indian Football Association has produced only one batch till now. The slow progress has been attributed to the fact that it has only one ground.

Other than the national academies, several clubs run their own academies like JCT Mills in Punjab, Sesa in Goa and the Mohun Bagan SAIL Football Academy in Durgapur.

Superstars Maradona and Rummenigge lend their names to new academies, but whether that will revitalise Indian football is uncertain

| By Elora Sen |

For the last few months, Indian football has existed in a parallel, almost schizophrenic reality. In the background, the embarrassing statistic of a FIFA world ranking of 143, below Surinam, Ethiopia and Botswana. In the foreground, a stream of high-profile visitors—Diego Maradona, Gerd “Der Bomber” Muller, Karl-Heinz Rummenigge—all promising new beginnings.

Maradona and Rummenigge's visits were connected to announcements that India—mostly Bengal—would be the home to world-class academies set up with the blessings of the great names of the game. Maradona's academy, to be grandly called the Indian Football School, will be housed over 28 acres under the Maheshtala Municipality in the South 24 Parganas district of the state.

